

As I said, a simpler and more attractive new tax regime... it can start and end at every stage of it.

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RK: *So, the finance ministry will consider in the months to come a reduction in personal income tax from 30 per cent to 25 per cent?*

No, I am not saying that!

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RK: *It will be applauded very loudly...*

No, I don't want applause. I have to work.

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RK: *Are you satisfied with the results you have got from the*

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AOK: *Is markets regulator Sebi investigating the Adani-Hindenburg saga?*

The markets regulator has already given its statement.

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UM: *The Adani Group is one of the important players in the infrastructure space. Is it big enough to be termed 'too big to fail'? There are suggestions that the recent setbacks suffered by the group may have an impact on some of our important infrastructure projects. Do you see any serious risks?*

Any institution on the verge of failure or any institution in a high-risk environment for an economy like

appointment have been given by the government as far as unemployment is concerned. We are also regularly doing programmes related to skilling and upskilling. We are also adding foreign languages in the training process considering overseas opportunities. Lastly, despite various issues for farmers in the year 2020, they have managed to get good produce. We have been keeping interest rates on farmers' loans under control. We have brought them under interest subvention so that their interest rates do not go up. Expansion of the Shree Anna scheme, installation of solar panels that have helped cut electricity bills and several other programmes have proved to be beneficial for farmers. We are committed to doubling farmers' income as promised.

“WE HAVE TRIED DEALING WITH INFLATION BOTH IN THE BUDGET AND OUTSIDE. WE ARE TRYING OUR BEST TO TAME INFLATION”

reduction in corporate taxes? Like, publicly and privately, we have seen you and others in the government nudging India Inc. to do more...

First of all, I would like to bring in the dimensions that the reduction in corporate tax rate has brought in. It has helped in cleaning up the balance sheet of the industry so that it could de-leverage to return a lot of its loans to banks. The problem of twin balance sheets was also addressed. Thus, the economy has received so many benefits from a reduction in corporate taxes. However, I don't expect the money saved through this measure to come into the industry this year itself. Yes, it will come in. But, more than that, it has helped clear a lot of backlogs. And I see that as a benefit.

India can have its impact. I can't say that this would be greater or lesser. I will give you the lived experience of 2019 where I would wonder which non-banking financial company might be in difficulty the following day. Like, who would fall off the cliff? If I had disclosed my fears at that time what would have happened? My job is to run the economy smoothly. Where I have to intervene, I intervene.

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AOK: *What is your view on inflation, unemployment and farmers' distress?*

We have addressed all of these issues in Budget 2023-24. We have tried dealing with inflation both in the Budget and outside. We are trying our best to tame inflation. Letters of

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UM: *What is your view on the national debt? How do you pare it down before it becomes a huge problem?*

Debt is a concern and we will bring it down. But why have we reached this level? I empathised with states when the economy dipped in 2020 as they did not have any money. As a result, back-to-back borrowings were undertaken; otherwise where would they be? However, even now we are in a better position than many other countries.

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RK: *How have you changed as a Finance Minister in the past few years?*

I am now a lot cooler when it comes to taking criticism! **BT**